

The Mummy RETURNS

A diplomatic initiative will ensure that a neglected and decaying mummy is restored in Hyderabad

[By Amarnath K. Menon |

When a newspaper article about the pathetic condition of a Pharaonic-era mummy in Hyderabad came up, coincidentally some weeks ahead of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's visit to Egypt, the Egyptian Ambassador to India Mohammed Higazy acted promptly. He wrote to the Andhra Pradesh Director of Archaeology and Museums P. Chenna Reddy offering legendary expertise from Egypt's Supreme Council of Antiquities (SCA) to restore it without cost. The mummy reveals bright decorations and writings in turquoise, terracotta and gold colours which have faded over time. But because of the poor conservation measures and the absence of an oxygen-free chamber, the crust of the embalmed body, lying in an airtight enclosure, is fragmenting at the face, shoulders and around its feet. The wrapping has started to peel off and the cracks are conspicuous. The mummy was brought by Nazeer Nawaz Jung, son-in-law of Mir Mehboob Ali Khan, the sixth Nizam or the ruler of the then Hyderabad state for £1,000 in 1920. He gifted it to the seventh Nizam Mir Osman Ali Khan, who donated it to the Hyderabad Museum, now the State Archaeological Museum, in 1930.

The mummy is of Nasihi, the 18-year-old daughter of the sixth Pharaoh of Egypt, dating back to 2,500 B.C., who is believed to have died during her pregnancy. Earlier efforts to restore the

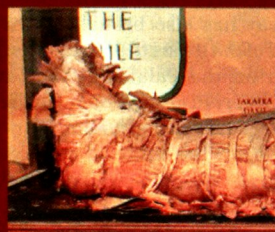
WALK LIKE AN EGYPTIAN



FACE: The crust is fragmenting at the face and shoulders



HEAD: Cracks have surfaced at many places



FEET: The outer layer is peeling off around the feet



Photographs by A PRABHAKAR RAO

mummy, one of six such unique objects in Indian museums, failed when the British Museum, London, made it clear that it could not spare its conservators. The irony is that even the Egypt Museum in Cairo did not respond at that time. Now, it is a diplomatic gesture—a cultural coup of sorts—that brings SCA's head of research Tarek El Awdy and the chief of its biological damage treatment division Samia Mohammed El Marghani to take up the preservation of Nasihi's embalmed body. The SCA is part of the Egyptian Ministry of Culture and responsible for the conservation, protection and regulation of all antiquities and archaeological excavations in Egypt. It has taken up conservation of mummies excavated from 118 pyramids and even attended to their preservation in museums around the world.

The challenge in conservation lies in making a mummy "come back to life" following the precepts of mummification. Conservation of decaying mummies involves evaluating the status of mummification and making